

Michael Psenka

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About Me

I'm a 4th year PhD student in EECS (BAIR) at UC Berkeley, advised by Prof. Yi Ma, and was a pure math undergraduate at Princeton (worked on Riemannian geometry and optimization). I specialize in mathematical approaches to pioneering deep learning algorithms, with a focus on advancing flow-based models like diffusion models. My work spans **disentangled representation learning**, **computer vision**, and **reinforcement learning**, aiming to develop fully autonomous and self-reliant deep learning methods—hyperparameters that tune themselves, and solutions extendable across various domains. In an era where data growth is plateauing, my goal is to maximize the utility of existing data through a mathematical understanding of the functions learned by models, their features, and how they interact with data.

Education

University of California, Berkeley

MS/PhD in Electrical Engineering and Computer Science

Berkeley, CA

Sept 2021 - Current

- *Coursework*: deep unsupervised learning, nonlinear systems and control, 3D vision, high-dimensional data analysis
- **GPA**: 4.0/4.0

Princeton University

BA in Mathematics, certificates in Applied Math and Computer Science

Princeton, NJ

Sept 2017 - June 2021

- *CS Coursework (grad)*: machine learning, deep learning, weakly supervised learning, reinforcement learning, information theory, complexity theory
- *Math Coursework (grad)*: stochastic calculus, geometric PDE, general relativity, quantum stat mech. (*undergrad*): probability theory, real/complex analysis, representation theory
- **GPA**: 3.6/4.0

Publications & Workshop Proceedings

M. Psenka*, A. Escontrela*, P. Abbeel, and Y. Ma (2024). **Learning a Diffusion Model Policy from Rewards via Q-Score Matching**. *ICML 2024*. [Link to paper](#).

M. Psenka, D. Pai, V. Raman, S. Sastry, and Y. Ma (2024). **Representation Learning through Manifold Flattening and Reconstruction**. *JMLR*. [Link to paper](#).

N. Rahmanian, M. Gupta, R. Soatto, S. Nachuri, **M. Psenka**, Y. Ma, and S. Sastry (2023). **Role of Uncertainty in Anticipatory Trajectory Prediction for a Ping-Pong Playing Robot**. *arXiv*. [Link to paper](#).

D. Pai, **M. Psenka**, C.-Y. Chiu, M. Wu, E. Dobriban, and Y. Ma (2023). **Pursuit of a discriminative representation for multiple subspaces via sequential games**. *Journal of the Franklin Institute*. [Link to paper](#).

X. Dai, S. Tong, M. Li, Z. Wu, **M. Psenka**, K. H. R. Chan, P. Zhai, Y. Yu, X. Yuan, H.-Y. Shum, et al. (2022). **CTRL: Closed-Loop Transcription to an LDR via Minimizing Rate Reduction**. *Entropy Journal*. [Link to paper](#).

R. Arbon*, M. Mannan*, **M. Psenka***, and S. Ragavan* (2022). **A Proof of The Triangular Ashbaugh-Benguria-Payne-Pólya-Weinberger Inequality**. *Journal of Spectral Theory*. [Link to paper](#).

M. Psenka and N. Boumal (2020). **Second-order optimization for tensors with fixed tensor-train rank**. *NeurIPS OPT 2020 Workshop*. [Link to paper](#).

M. Psenka, T. Birdal, and L. Guibas (2020). **Reconstruction Without Registration**. *IROS 2020 geometric methods workshop*. [Link to paper](#).

Awards

2020	Peter A. Greenberg '77 Memorial Prize , won for solving an open problem in spectral geometry. Awarded for outstanding accomplishments in Mathematics by juniors	Princeton
2018	HackPrinceton First Place , won first place at intercollegiate hackathon for developing A.I.D.A.N., a chatbot that lets users interact with their dataset with statistical and machine learning tools. Link to project .	Princeton
2018	Manfred Pyka Memorial Prize , awarded to outstanding Physics undergraduates who have shown excellence in course work and promise in independent research	Princeton
2021	Sigma Xi Honors Society , academic honors society for scientific research	Princeton

Work Experience

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Co-head instructor, lecturer

University of California, Berkeley

Berkeley, CA

June 2022 - Aug 2022

- Organized and taught lectures for CS 70, an undergraduate class for discrete math and probability theory
- [Link to class page](#)

Undergraduate researcher

Stanford University

Palo Alto, CA

June 2020 - Aug 2020

- Worked with Dr. Tolga Birdal on a novel approach to multi-view reconstruction in computer vision that bypasses pairwise view registration

Undergraduate researcher

Princeton University

Princeton, NJ

June 2019 - Sept 2019

- Worked with Prof. Nicolas Boumal funded by the National Science Foundation through award DMS-1719558
- Successfully developed a state-of-the-art method for computing analytic Hessians and second order optimization over tensor train manifolds

Software engineer

Moovila, Inc.

Charleston, SC

June 2018 - Aug 2018, '17, '16

- Developed a machine learning algorithm for workplace analytics, and improved search engine for quicker and more robust search
- Worked through a patent application, co-inventor in patent for proprietary software
- Worked closely with dev team, participating in stand-up and sprints regularly

Skills

Programming Python (JAX, pytorch, numpy), C#, C, MATLAB, Java, HTML/CSS, JavaScript

Miscellaneous Linux, Shell, $\LaTeX$, Git, AWS

Interests

Piano	Played since I was 3. Grew up mostly classical, got into jazz playing at restaurants in middle/high school
Princeton Pianist Ensemble	All pieces arranged in-house, charity performances, virtual concerts during quarantine (link)
Snowboarding	The more trees, the better
Games	Smash bros, chess, or anything in between; always up to learn a new game